

Liberators Network #2: From Purpose To Practice

Clarify the purpose of your initiative together, and how you will collaborate to achieve it



Hey There Liberator!

We can tell you from experience how rewarding it is to start communities. Whether it is a regional Liberator meetup or a community in your organization, it is such a great way to give people a place where they can give *and* get help from peers on the challenges they face.

But how do you start? In this series, we share our most successful strings for starting meetups, initiatives, and communities. We know from experience that they work, are fun to facilitate, and put a smile on people's faces. In other words, you can rely on these strings to get started!

With the instructions in this guide, you should be able to run this workshop smoothly. But if you need help, we can also facilitate this workshop with you remotely. Contact us at info@theliberators.com for availability and pricing.

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Flow

Step 1: Opening	 2 min
Step 2: Clarify Your Purpose With Nine Whys	  30 min
Step 3: Clarify Your Principles With Min Specs	  30 min
Step 4: Determine Whom You Need To Involve With 1-2-4-ALL	  15 min
Step 5: Consider Your Structure With 1-2-4-ALL	  15 min
Step 6: Identify Practices With 25/10 Crowd Sourcing	  15 min
Step 7: 15% Solutions	  10 min
Step 8: Closing	 3 min
Total duration	 120 min



The Purpose Of This String

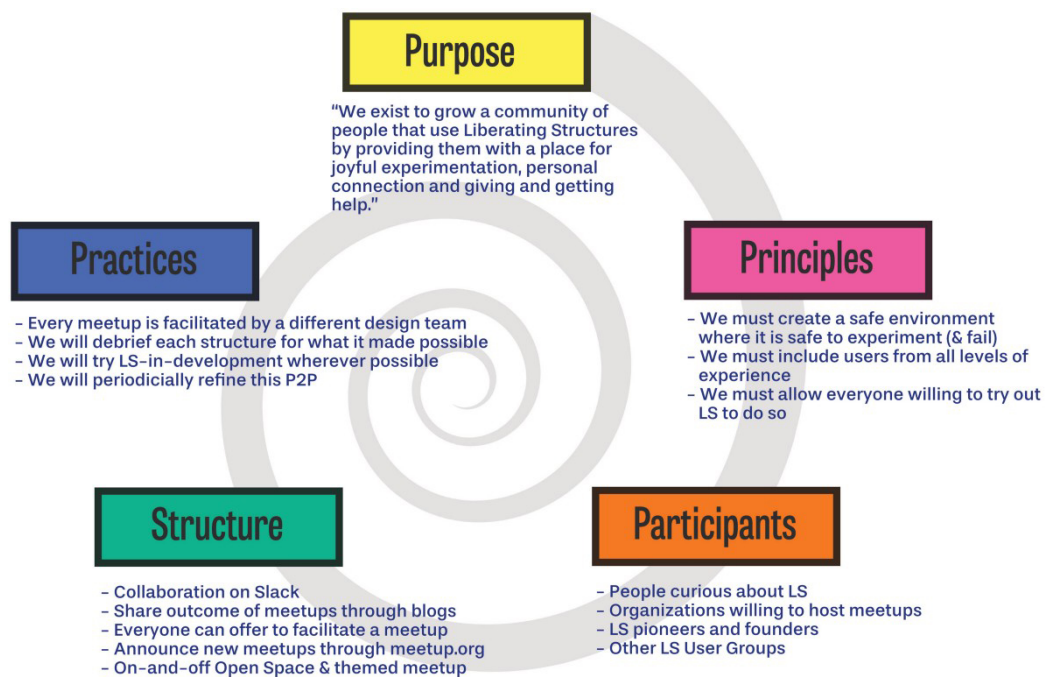
With your first gathering behind, now is a good moment to start thinking about the larger opportunities that this group offers – together. If you do, it is more likely that your meetup will endure and draw in more people.

The Liberating Structure [Purpose to Practice](#) provides a good framework for this. Although a full P2P takes more time than the meetup allows, we designed this string to tap into the five core components of a resilient initiative: purpose, principles, participants, structure, and practices. We recommend that you revisit and update the P2P periodically.

This string is designed for two hours. If you don't have that time, you can break it up into two sessions (e.g. purpose and principles in one, and the rest in the other). An example of a Purpose-to-Practice is included below. This was created by the Dutch Liberating Structures User Group, and is occasionally updated.

Repetition And Learning

In this string, you'll notice several 1–2–4–ALL's. This is a good example of the Liberating Structure principle "repetition is also a form of learning". By doing 1–2–4–ALL twice in a row, people start building the skill to run these structures on their own – without facilitation. It illustrates how Liberating Structures [are intended as skills for users, not facilitators](#).



Developed by Keith McCandless & Henri Lipmanowicz ([liberatingstructures.com](#))

How To Prepare



Group Size

This string of Liberating Structures is feasible from 4 participants and onward. We've successfully scaled it up to 100 participants (both virtually and in-person) without significant issues.

Intended Audience

You can run this string with pretty much any audience. We've used it with communities of Scrum Masters, new teams, with the Dutch Liberating Structures User Group, with our Liberator Meetups, and even at a birthday party.

Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

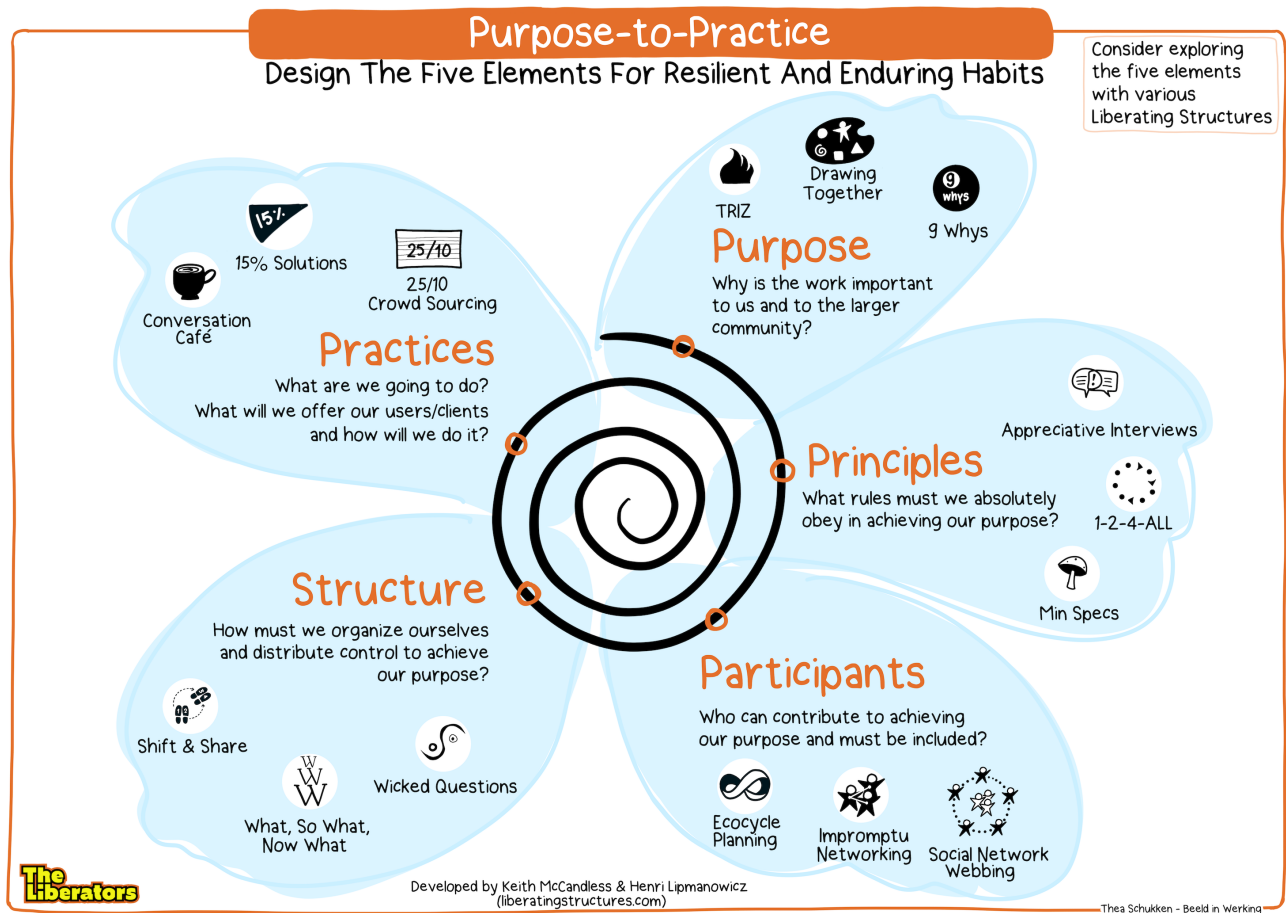
Material

- Optionally, [The Liberators Meetup Starter Kit](#) that patrons in the "Liberator"-tier receive for free
- Prepare basic slides or a virtual whiteboard to collect your insights. You can also [include this poster](#) about Purpose-to-Practice there.
- Register for the [free 25/10 Crowd Sourcing app](#) created by David Heath and create a "Challenge" there (see Step 6).

Resources

- Blog post: [Shaping Resilient Initiatives With Purpose-to-Practice](#)
- [Purpose to Practice](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: [Start a Liberating Structures User Group](#)





🕒 2 min

Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then introduce the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.

Step 2: Clarify Your Purpose With Nine Whys

"[Start with Why](#)" is the title of a well-known book by Simon Sinek. It isn't any different for your initiative, team, meetup, or community. Here too, it is important to start by answering the question of why it exists. If this purpose is appealing, it will draw in more people over time. The Liberating Structure [Nine Whys](#) is a great way to think about this with a group. It starts from the personal motivations and reasons and builds to the start of a shared purpose.

Invitation

"This group exists in order to "

Steps

1. **2 min** Individually, ask everyone to compile a list of the reasons, hopes, and aspirations that brings them to this gathering.
2. Provide an overview of the steps that are coming up so that people know what to expect once they're in their breakouts.
3. **8 min** Invite everyone to form pairs and move them into separate breakouts. In there, people interview each other in turns (4 min each) about their list. Interviewers only ask "Why is that (item/entire list) important for you?" while taking notes.
4. **8 min** Invite pairs to join another pair in new breakouts. In there, the pairs exchange notes and notice patterns about what brings people to this group. In the final minutes, ask the groups to complete the sentence "This group exists in order to".
5. **5 min** Back in the main channel, each group briefly presents its purpose statement. Together, you can pick one that jumps out. Or just notice patterns across the statements.

Examples

- This meetup exists to put a stop to dehumanizing and ineffective ways of working in this organization
- This meetup exists to provide a space where Scrum practitioners can give and get help to overcome the tough impediments they face in their work

Our Findings

- Groups can easily get stuck in the process of coming up with a great purpose statement. It is important to work empirically here, too. Start with a quick and raw version and improve it over time as you learn more about this meetup.
- A compelling purpose can never be fully achieved. A purpose can also be very strong when it is about stopping things (e.g. "this meetup exists in order to STOP...")

Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Make the Purpose of Your Work Together Clear with 'Nine Whys'](#)



Step 3: Clarify Your Principles With Min Specs



Now that you have some clarity on the purpose of your group, the next step is to think about the rules and principles you must be followed in order to be, and remain, successful in that purpose.

In order to avoid long lists of rules, it is important to focus groups on the essential rules. The Liberating Structure [Min Specs](#) is a great structure for this. It invites people to first think as broadly as possible – encouraging all sorts of creative and outside-of-the-box ideas – and then funnels it back down to what is absolutely essential.

Invitation

"What are the essential rules we must absolutely follow in order to succeed in achieving our purpose?"

Steps

1. **2 min** Ask everyone to individually and silently generate a list of must-dos and must-not-dos.
2. **8 min** Invite people into small groups (3–5) and move them into separate breakouts. Together, they consolidate their lists and expand it to make it as long as possible (Max Specs).
3. **8 min** Bring everyone back to the main channel and explain the next step. Once they're back in their breakouts, ask the groups to test each of the items on their lists against the purpose statement. Let them ask: "Can we still be successful with this group if we broke this rule?". Each group removes all the items that aren't absolutely essential (Min Specs).
4. **8 min** When everyone is back in the main channel, collect the remaining rules on a shared workspace, removing duplicates and clarifying as needed.

Our Findings

- We often encourage teams to generate more rules for the "Max Specs"–part. This drives more creative and less-obvious rules that may end up being super important. At the same time, we always encourage teams to be more minimalistic during the "Min Specs"–round
- It is better to end with two, three, or maybe four clear rules that people will absolutely adhere too than to generate a list of a dozen abstract principles. If you find that people are getting stuck in abstract principles (e.g. "We have to work to understand each other"), ask them what behavior fits (or doesn't fit) with the principle (e.g. "We demonstrate active listening behaviors to each other" or "We don't criticize what people say").

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "Min Specs" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Use 'Min Specs' to help groups discover what is absolutely essential](#)



Step 4: Determine Whom You Need To Involve With 1-2-4-ALL

The current group you are with, may not be the full group you have in mind. Who else needs to be included in order to achieve your purpose? The Liberating Structure [1-2-4-ALL](#) is a great way to quickly surface the most important participants to involve, invite, or acknowledge (when they're already present).

Invitation

"Who must be included to achieve our purpose?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask people to first individually consider the most relevant participants or groups of participants, writing them down for themselves as needed.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs and move them into breakouts. There, they quickly share their lists and add or remove participants.
3. **4 min** Invite people into groups of four, preferably by keeping the pairs together and move them into new breakouts. Ask the groups to share their lists and build on them.
4. **5 min** Together, collect all the participants on a shared workspace and remove duplicates as needed.

Our Findings

- As with all the steps in this string, don't fall into the temptation to create exhaustive lists. Whom do you need to involve right now? Who is most critical to your success? Start there and expand later.
- 1-2-4-ALL is purposefully quick. Even though people may individually struggle to generate much, the group as a whole will.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)





Step 5: Consider Your Structure With 1-2-4-ALL

One of the tenets of Liberating Structures is that control is distributed, rather than in one person or a small group. How will you organize to distribute control while also remaining one group?

Invitation

"How will we organize to distribute control?"

Steps

1. **1 min** Ask people to first individually consider how this group can distribute control.
2. **2 min** Invite people into pairs and move them into breakouts. There, they quickly share their ideas and build on them.
3. **4 min** Invite people into groups of four, preferably by keeping the pairs together and moving them into new breakouts. Ask the groups to share their ideas and build on them.
4. **5 min** Together, collect all the ideas from the participants on a shared workspace and remove duplicates as needed.

Examples

Thinking about control, distribution and structure don't always come naturally to groups. Who controls what happens during each gathering? How do you collaborate in a way that allows everyone to contribute, rather than one or two people taking the lead all the time? For example:

- Every gathering is hosted by another member of this group.
- Every gathering is prepared by mixing pairs of facilitators that work together to both prepare and run the gathering.
- The group agrees to set up a page on Meetup.org to schedule and coordinate additional meetups.
- For communication, the group agrees to use WhatsApp or Slack.

Our Findings

- This second use of 1-2-4-ALL is a good example of the Liberating Structure principle "repetition is also a form of learning". By doing 1-2-4-ALL twice in a row, but with a different question, people start building the skill to run these structures on their own – without facilitation.



Step 6: Identify Practices With 25/10 Crowd Sourcing

Now that you have more clarity on the purpose, the principles, the structure, and the participants, it is important to consider what it is that you will be doing together; *the practices*. The Liberating Structure [25/10 Crowd Sourcing](#) offers a good way to rapidly capture such ideas and build commitment from people.

Invitation

"What is a topic or practice that is relevant to our purpose and that you'd like to dig deeper into?"

Steps

1. Share the link to the 25/10 Crowd Sourcing challenge that you prepared earlier in the [free online app](#).
2. **2 min** Individually, ask everyone to silently submit one big idea they have for this group.
3. **8 min** Explain the next steps. In a moment, you will be starting the voting session. Ask people to rate each idea on a scale of 1 to 5, 1 meaning "Meh. I wouldn't commit to joining this session" and 5 meaning "Love it! If this session is hosted, I commit to being there". Start the voting session in the app and move to the next round when people have voted. Repeat five times.
4. **5 min** Conclude the voting and share the link with results from the app with everyone. Briefly collect the top 5 ideas. There's no need to dig deeper into them now.

Our findings

- 25/10 Crowd Sourcing is purposefully anonymous to give everyone an equal voice. Resist the temptation to ask who suggested an idea (regardless of its score).
- The 25/10 Crowd Sourcing was built by David Heath. David is a friend and an active member of the global Liberating Structures community. [Buy him a coffee](#) if you like it.

Resources

- The [original article](#) for "1-2-4-ALL" from the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: [Engage Everyone Simultaneously in Generating Questions, Ideas, and Suggestions with 1-2-4-ALL](#)



Step 7: 15% Solutions

We like to end sessions on a personal note by asking people what it is that they want to contribute to the success of this meetup. A good start is the top 5 of ideas that originated from the 25/10 Crowd Sourcing. No matter how small, if everyone makes one small change, together this generates large change. The Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#) is super useful for this.

Invitation

"What is your personal 15% Solution to contribute to this meetup? What is something you can do that you do without permission from other or resources you don't have access to?"

Steps

1.  Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2.  Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find ways to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).

Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?".
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.

Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blogpost: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

Step 8: Closing

If you have the time, do a quick debrief with the group. A simple Liberating Structure for this is [Impromptu Networking](#) ("What did you observe, think or feel while participating in this meetup?"). Draw out some salient patterns from the whole group, but keep it short.

Make A Group Picture

Take a picture of the whole group (ask for permission). A great way to give energy to an otherwise static picture is to invite people to "say Hi! with a picture" to a Liberator Meetup elsewhere in the world. You can tag them in your message (e.g. "Hi to Liberators in Pittsburgh, US!" or "Hi to Liberators in Bern, Switzerland!"). You can find us on Twitter [here](#).

Closing

Thank everyone for their presence and announce when the next meetup will take place.



After The Meetup



With this string, you should be able to get your meetup started. What is important now is to follow up on the ideas that you generated in this session.

- We've always found it helpful to schedule at least 3 or 4 dates for upcoming meetups. This makes it easy for people to sign-up and know what to expect.
- Share the Purpose-to-Practice somewhere so it is accessible to everyone in the meetup. We always like to turn it into a nice poster that we can bring to all future meetups (as a reminder and to update as needed).

Learn and Grow, Together

If you're stuck with a design or have other questions about this design, reach out to us at info@theliberators.com or other members of the Liberators Support Group. Let's learn and grow, together!

Help Us Improve This String

We are eager to learn from your experience of this string. You probably discovered much about the flow of the string, the use of the invitations, and the impact on the group. What did it make possible for you or your team? What unexpected surprises did you run into? What would make the string even better? [Help us learn from your experience by sharing it with us.](#) It only takes a few minutes.

Share Your Outcomes

There is bound to be plenty of learning going on in your session. If you can, please share some of those results with the wider community. We always like to share a collage of pictures (with permission) or a short video. It is a nice way to inspire people to join your meetup, or for other people to start their own in their region.

Try Our Other Strings

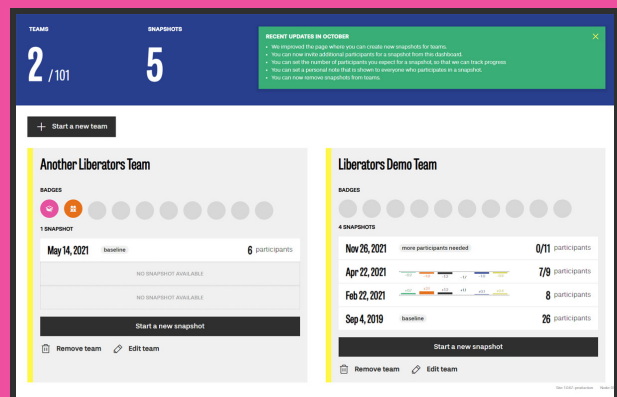
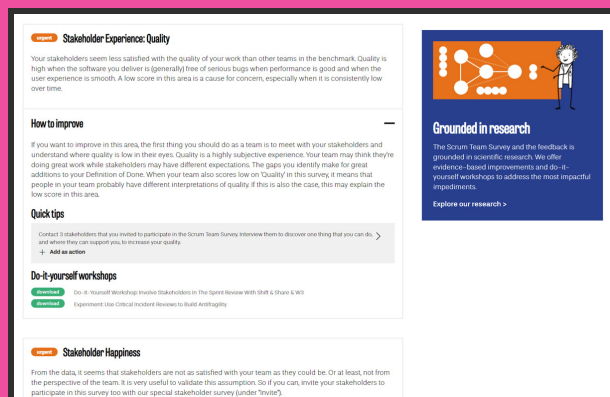
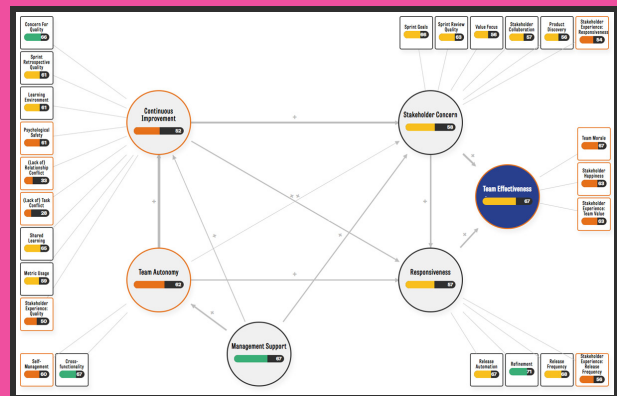
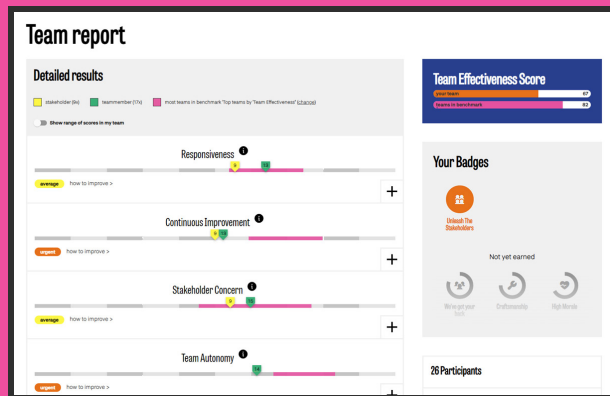
This string is part of our [Liberator Network series](#). It probably triggered in-depth conversations, valuable insights, and tangible next steps.

We have many more strings for you to explore with your team, organization, or community! We offer strings to create a strategy, determine your personal impact, and to face your deepest fears! We add new strings every week.

You can find more free and premium strings about our Scrum Mythbusters series [here](#). Or browse all our strings [here](#). Give them a try, and unleash the superpowers of your team, organization, and community!

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	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Maintain one or many teams from a single dashboard		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Insights		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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Unleashing Teams All Over The World

We are The Liberators – Barry Overeem and Christiaan Verwijs. Our mission is to create data-driven products to unleash the superpowers of teams all over the world. We do this together with a growing community of patrons.

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